* * *

In December 1923 the Conservative party lost the general election and the very first Labour government was ushered into power in Britain. One of the first acts of the new prime minister, Ramsey MacDonald, was to extend official recognition to the Soviet government in February 1924.[16] If the Labour government was trying to differentiate itself from the previous two administrations, it could not have chosen a more appropriate way of doing so. The world had moved on from the days when Karl Bravin was ignored and maligned by the Persian government. Soviet representatives now resided in Tehran, Kabul, Ankara and even London. And yet, MacDonald's actions were not entirely unforeseen, nor were they a result of some sort of socialist solidarity, as might be expected. Economic pragmatism had dictated Britain's conclusion of the Soviet Trade Agreement in 1921, and so it did in 1924 with the issue of formal recognition. The trouble with the agreement of 1921 is that it had not stimulated trade between the two countries to the extent that had been hoped for. British business still felt wary of dealing with Russia when no British consulates existed there to help protect their interests. Thus, formal diplomatic relations needed to be established.[17]

After 1923, the majority of those who had directed Britain's foreign policy since the First World War were no longer in government. Curzon, Lloyd George, Montagu, Chelmsford, Hardinge and Churchill – all had left office one way or another by 1924. It is true that the Labour government did not last for long, and that by the end of the year the Conservative party was back in power (helped by the Zinoviev scandal). Nevertheless, by this point Lloyd George and Montagu had been forced to resign, while Chelmsford and Hardinge had retired. Churchill was one of the few who not only remained in government, but of course went on to greater things after the 1920s. By the time of the Second World War, Churchill would come to have his own problems with the Soviet government – and perhaps, just like